

SENATE BILL 1709

By Taylor

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49,  
relative to educator licensure.

WHEREAS, knowledge of our government and its structure, history, and founding principles are paramount to a functioning society and civically engaged electorate; and

WHEREAS, the education system in Tennessee must be well suited to prepare our citizens to understand their constitutional rights, their role in government, and the importance of civic engagement; and

WHEREAS, the need is great to ensure that teachers are well versed in civics and understand the importance of teaching the same; now, therefore,

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 49, Chapter 5, Part 1, is amended by adding the following as a new section:

(a) This section is known and may be cited as the "Tennessee Civics Education Act."

(b) Beginning July 1, 2027, a person seeking the first issuance of a practitioner teacher license or practitioner occupational teacher license must achieve a passing score on the United States civics test described in subdivision (c)(1) in order to obtain the license.

(c) The department of education shall:

(1) Prepare a United States civics test composed of one hundred (100) questions collected from the questions that are set forth within the civics test administered by the United States citizenship and immigration services to persons seeking to become naturalized citizens;

(2) Beginning January 1, 2027, administer the United States civics test described in subdivision (c)(1) to persons seeking the first issuance of a practitioner teacher license or practitioner occupational teacher license; and

(3) Provide a person who achieves a passing score on the United States civics test described in subdivision (c)(1) with a certificate of completion.

(d) A person must correctly answer at least seventy (70) questions to receive a passing score on the United States civics test described in subdivision (c)(1).

(e) The department shall not provide persons seeking the first issuance of a practitioner teacher license or practitioner occupational teacher license with any remediation or civics instruction in preparation for the United States civics test described in subdivision (c)(1); provided, that the department shall provide links on its website to reference materials and instructional resources the department deems appropriate or helpful to such persons in preparation for the test.

SECTION 2. This act takes effect July 1, 2026, the public welfare requiring it.